



“I looked on **child rearing** not only as a **work of love** and a **duty**, but as a **profession** as **interesting** and **challenging** as **any** ... in the **world**. ”

ROSE KENNEDY, POLITICAL FAMILY MATRIARCH, 1974

can be related by blood, family, or milk. From ancient times, some mothers fed their babies with “bottles.” Devices included horns with leather teats and jugs with spouts, and rather than milk substitutes, mixtures such as wine and honey were fed to babies by the ancient Greeks.

However, until the discoveries of Louis Pasteur in the 19th century and new techniques to keep milk fresh for longer (pasteurization), bottle-feeding led to high infant mortality rates. The invention of infant formula in 1867 gave mothers another alternative to breastfeeding for the first year or two.

“Deciding **not to** have **children** is a very, very **hard decision** for a **woman** to make ... we **call** these **women selfish**. ”

CAITLIN MORAN, *HOW TO BE A WOMAN*, 2011

In medieval Europe the upper classes outsourced child-rearing to wet nurses, nannies, and boarding schools, whereas the working classes often had a closer, nurturing experience with their offspring, who were often a necessity as future wage earners. Motherhood changed little up until the 18th century when enlightened ideas helped it become more highly valued, though women were still confined to family life in the home.

By the Victorian period, many Western societies began to reject wet-nursing, on anecdotal evidence that more infants died in a wet-nurse's care. With the rise of feminism in the 19th century, many women no longer wanted to be seen as just baby-making machines. However, until new contraception methods appeared in the 20th century (see pp. 278–279), they had limited control over reproduction. During World War II, with women in demand for factory jobs, nurseries sprang up in Britain, ensuring that mothers could work away from home.

The modern mother

During the 20th century, the increase in access to contraception and childcare, not to mention lower maternal mortality rates, meant that motherhood became a more positive choice for women in the West, rather than an expectation. The role of the mother has changed even more in the 21st century in terms of age, marital status, and sexual orientation. Nonetheless, women around the world still often find themselves caught between cultural expectations and the practical realities of mothering, such as arranging childcare and breastfeeding.